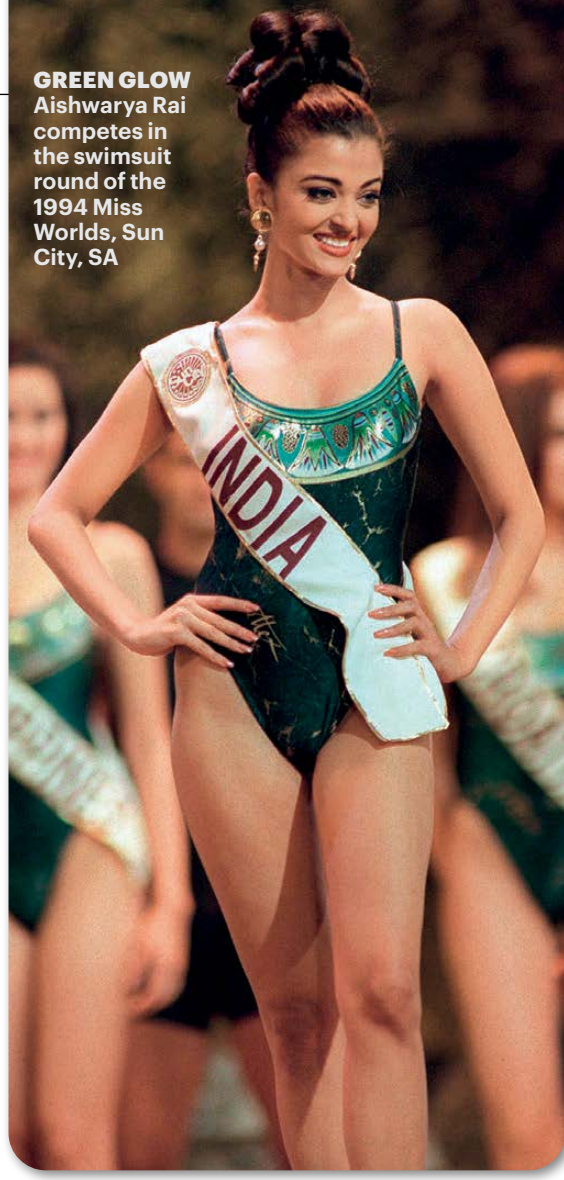


GREEN GLOW Aishwarya Rai competes in the swimsuit round of the 1994 Miss Worlds, Sun City, SA

AFP

THE BEAUTIFUL RUN

» **1996: Sushmita Sen makes her Bollywood debut in *Dastak*. A year later, Aishwarya Rai follows suit with Mani Ratnam's *Iruvar***

» **1997/'99: Diana Hayden wins Miss World title, followed by Yukta Mookhey**

» **2000: India makes history by sweeping all three pageants with Lara Dutta winning Miss Universe, Priyanka Chopra Miss World and Dia Mirza the Asia Pacific International crown**

» **2003: Aishwarya becomes global brand ambassador for L'Oréal Paris, an association that continues till date. Becomes first Indian actress to serve on the Cannes Film Festival jury**

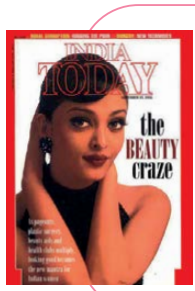
» **2004: Aishwarya makes Hollywood debut with Gurinder Chadha's *Bride & Prejudice***

» **2015: Priyanka Chopra becomes first Indian actor to headline a US TV show with *Quantico***

» **2017: Manushi Chillar becomes Miss World; India ties with Venezuela for the most number of wins**

DID YOU KNOW?

Persis Khambatta, winner of the second Miss India pageant, was the first Indian model to make it to the big screen internationally. She played Lt Ilia in *Star Trek* and was also the first Indian to present an Oscar



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Dec. 15, 1994

Special features **Educating Aishwarya**

Sure, there was poise and carriage, but that comes from being India's most sought-after model. For those who watched the Miss India contest where she lost the crown owing to a momentary flash of arrogance, this was a different Aishwarya Rai. The difference was intangible...

–Archana Jahagirdar

seemed to have become a powerhouse of beauties with brains as more and more brown-skinned women dominated the pageant scene. Moulding these young ladies into paragons of perfection was an exalted panel of experts—Sabira Merchant for etiquette training, dietitian Anjali Mukherjee, Bharat Dagombe for hair and make-up, dentist Dr Sandesh Mayekar, cosmetic physician Dr Jamuna Pai and others.

The accomplishments would pave the way for the multi-billion dollar beauty industry to target India and lead to a rise of ancillary industries like hair and make-up, styling and fitness centres, which in turn opened up avenues for women entering the job market. Author and former model Shobhaa De notes how the wins "were perfectly and shrewdly timed" for international cosmetics brands to make an entry into the Indian market. It wasn't just about the looks. The winners were "articulate, confident women who inspired and encouraged other women to step up and follow their dreams", adds De.

As models became hot property, it made perfect sense for the film industry to lure them in with the glitz and glamour the big screen provided. Former Miss India winner Juhi Chawla had already shown the way, busting the myth that models cannot act and proving her mettle as a leading lady. Sushmita and Aishwarya would follow, followed by the likes of Gul Panag, Lara Dutta and Priyanka Chopra. Many of them went from strength to strength, even starring in international projects. May their tribe increase. ■